

Past Continuous

CEFR A2

Lesson Pack · summary, worksheet & answer key

Quick answer

The past continuous (was/were + verb-ing) is for an action in progress in the past. Use it for:

- 1 An action in progress at a past moment — At 8pm I was cooking dinner.
- 2 A background action interrupted by another — I was reading when the phone rang.
- 3 Two actions at the same time — She was singing while he was cooking.

Use was with I/he/she/it and were with you/we/they. For the short action that interrupts, use the past simple (the phone rang).

At a glance

Form	Structure	Example
Affirmative	subject + was/were + verb- ing	She was working .
Negative	subject + wasn't/weren't + verb-ing	They weren't listening .
Question	Was/Were + subject + verb-ing?	Were you sleeping?

Learning objectives

- Can form the past continuous with was/were + -ing in all three forms (CEFR A2).
- Can combine the past continuous and past simple to show an interrupted action.
- Can use 'when' and 'while' correctly with the two tenses.

Practice worksheet

Circle the correct option. Past Continuous · CEFR A2

Name: _____

Date: _____

1. At 8 o'clock last night, I ____ dinner.

- A. cooked
- C. cook

- B. was cooking
- D. am cooking

2. I was reading when the phone ____.

- A. rang
- C. rings

- B. was ringing
- D. ring

3. They ____ TV when I arrived.

- A. watched
- C. watch

- B. were watching
- D. are watching

4. You ____ sleeping when I called.

- A. was
- C. are

- B. were
- D. is

5. I ____ the answer, so I put my hand up.

- A. was knowing
- C. were knowing

- B. knew
- D. know

6. While she ____, he was cooking.

- A. was studying
- C. studies

- B. studied
- D. is studying

7. We ____ listening — sorry, can you repeat that?

- A. weren't
- C. didn't

- B. wasn't
- D. not were

8. I was crossing the road when a car ____ round the corner.

- A. was coming
- C. comes

- B. came
- D. come

9. Rewrite with the same meaning: 'During our walk, it suddenly started to rain.'

- A. We walked and then it rained.
- C. It rained before our walk.

- B. We were walking when it started to rain.
- D. We didn't walk because of the rain.

10. What ____ you ____ at midnight?

- A. were / doing
- C. did / doing

- B. was / doing
- D. are / doing

Answer key

Correct answers with explanations · for the teacher

1. **B. was cooking** — An action in progress at a past time takes the past continuous: 'was cooking'.
2. **A. rang** — The short action that interrupts the longer one takes the past simple: 'rang'.
3. **B. were watching** — The background action already in progress takes the past continuous: 'were watching'.
4. **B. were** — With 'you' the past continuous uses 'were': 'You were sleeping'.
5. **B. knew** — State verbs like 'know' take the past simple: 'knew'.
6. **A. was studying** — Two actions happening at the same time in the past both take the past continuous: 'was studying'.
7. **A. weren't** — Past continuous negative with 'we' uses 'weren't': 'weren't listening'.
8. **B. came** — The short event that interrupts takes the past simple: 'came'.
9. **B. We were walking when it started to rain.** — The walk (in progress) + the rain (sudden event) = past continuous + past simple.
10. **A. were / doing** — A past-continuous question with 'you' uses 'were': 'What were you doing?'.